

Proposed data centre project deferred to newly elected Quinte West council - Belleville Intelligencer

Category: Quinte West Data Centers, Water & Ecology | Evidence ID: #137

Archived: 2026-10-04 20:17

- **Original URL:** <https://www.intelligencer.ca/news/proposed-data-centre-project-deferred-to-newly-elected-quinte-west-council/>
 - **Research Category:** Quinte West Data Centers, Water & Ecology
 - **Archival File:** 137_www_intelligencer_ca_news_proposed-data-centre-project-.pdf
 - **Extraction Status:** Full Web Transcript PDF
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Source Content

A newly elected Quinte West city council will decide on any future rezoning application for a \$320 million micro data centre proposed for the former Saputo cheese factory in the city. After fielding comments for more than two hours in a raucous public meeting Thursday night at City Hall, the Planning Advisory Committee unanimously agreed to postpone moving the proposal ahead leaving its future uncertain. Public committee member J.D. Brown suggested the matter be deferred until after the October 26 municipal election to let the next council decide the fate of the proposal. "I motion to defer this, I would like to see a new council decide on this," Brown said, sparking resounding applause throughout the packed public gallery and in an adjacent room holding a spillover crowd. The decision officially pauses an application by TrueNorth Sustainable Infrastructure based in Kamloops, B.C., to rezone the former cheese plant property at 7 Riverside Drive needed in order to build an 8 MW data centre. The Intelligencer first reported on the proposed data centre application on June 25, 2026 after a first public meeting was held to solicit input from Quinte West residents. The deferral Thursday evening marked the end of a second public meeting filled with dozens of irate speakers heckling and hurling emotional catcalls into the chambers. Not a single member of the public spoke in favour of the push to build a new data centre. True North representative Shawn Bouchard did his best to assure residents there would be minimal impacts from the micro data centre. Bouchard said the project would not tap local water sources and instead would operate via a dry-cooling system. He also pledged the Canadian-owned centre would draw less electricity of up to \$7 million a year, far smaller than hyperscale data centres in the United States. The data centre would employ equipment that would operate quietly as to not effect nearby residences, he contended. As an example, Bouchard showed a video for comparison of a 6.5 MW Telus data centre of similar size in Kamloops, B.C., in which he repeatedly asserted the noise was minimal close to and far away from the building. Chris King, CEO of Quinte Economic Development Commission, spoke briefly following a meeting of QEDC members to discuss the data centre earlier in the day. He posited the data centre would fill a void left at the vacant former Saputo plant given a covenant by the former owners that prohibits any new dairy firm from assuming the property which makes it difficult to attract new companies for the building. Some residents who addressed the public meeting were near tears as they appealed to the committee from the podium to turn down the data centre application. They expressed fears for the health, environmental, economic and noise impacts on their families and neighbours, especially those who live within earshot of the proposed Riverside Drive site just north of Highway 401 off Glen Miller Road. Other speakers asked why Quinte West even needs a

new data centre and whether the city had done its own independent studies to determine if hosting such a facility would be warranted against potential risks of chiller diesel fuel leaking on site or potential fires requiring emergency services. The public gallery grilled True North's Bouchard, challenging the veracity of studies paid and presented so far by the company.